HAIR LOSS 08

Melatonin

Hormone the body makes mainly at night; most products are synthetic



CLASS	STUDIED FOR	HUMAN EVIDENCE	US STATUS
Hormone	Sleep, hair loss	Controlled human trials	Dietary supplement · not FDA approved

STUDIED FOR

- **Falling asleep** — HUMAN
- **Insomnia, 55 and over** — HUMAN
- **Jet lag** — HUMAN
- **Female pattern loss** — HUMAN + ANIMAL

Scalp use is off-label. The only randomized hair trial was a 40-woman pilot; the other scalp studies had no placebo group.

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Melatonin ▶ Night signal ▶ Body clock ▶ Sleep-wake cycle

- **Made by the body** mainly at night; helps run the sleep-wake cycle
- **Hair follicle effects** reported in animal and cell studies
- **Scalp use** raised blood melatonin, but below the normal night peak
- **For hair loss in people,** the mechanism is not established

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

CONTROLLED TRIALS
LEVEL 4 OF 5

- Sleep: meta-analyses of 19 and 22 trials
- Small effects on time to fall asleep
- Hair: one pilot RCT in 40 women

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Long-term safety
- Hair effect in men
- Hair effect in larger trials

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE	ROUTES STUDIED
3.5 to 4 hours (Circadin, EU label)	By mouth (sleep); on the scalp (hair studies)
PHARMACOKINETICS	**SOLD AS**
Liver metabolism, mainly CYP1A (Circadin, EU label)	Dietary supplement (US); prescription in the EU and UK
MONITORED IN TRIALS	**SPORT (WADA)**
Time to fall asleep, sleep quality; growing-hair share	Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

FDA	Not approved; sold as a dietary supplement
EMA	Circadin (2007), Slenyto (2018): Rx for sleep
MHRA	Prescription-only medicine
WADA	Not on the 2026 list

REFERENCES

1. NIH NCCIH, Melatonin: what you need to know, May 2024
2. EMA, Circadin product information (EPAR)
3. Fischer et al., Br J Dermatol, melatonin scalp solution in women, Feb 2004

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